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LabStart Hiring Team

LabStart

RE: OPERATIONS ASSOCIATE

Dear LabStart Hiring Team,

I'm applying for the Operations Associate role because I genuinely like this kind of work — the unglamorous engine underneath a small, ambitious team. I've spent fifteen years inside lean, mission-driven organizations, and the roles I've enjoyed most were the ones where I got to spot what was broken, fix it, and write down how it works so it stays fixed. **That's the job description here, and it's the job I actually want.**

On the CRM and systems side: I owned Salesforce CRM administration end to end at Zayo Group — Einstein, Marketing Cloud, data hygiene, automations, and reporting — and at Lytics I administered an enterprise customer data platform for a major account, keeping the data clean and the reporting trustworthy. I also helped build the customer-delivery playbook at Lytics, which is exactly the kind of SOP work this role is asking for: document the process well enough that it survives someone else running it.

On automation specifically, I'm not coming to this cold. I'm currently a founding technical advisor at a small startup where I build AI-agent workflows — Claude Code sub-agents, RAG pipelines, prompt libraries — whose whole purpose is taking manual, repetitive work off a small team's plate. I'd bring that same instinct to LabStart's tool stack from day one.

On the numbers side, I have an MBA, which is where my comfort with budgets, expense coding, and reconciling a list that doesn't quite add up comes from. I don't have hands-on nonprofit grant-budget experience yet, but the underlying skill — tracking spend against a budget and knowing when to flag it — is one I'm confident in.

I'm also genuinely comfortable in the "everyone wears many hats" environment LabStart describes, and it's not a recent adjustment for me — it's how my career started. My first stops were internships at small, lean, mission-driven organizations: the Humanitarian OpenStreetMap Team, Cadasta (a land and resource-rights registry nonprofit), and the Bonobo Conservation Initiative. Since then I've worked inside seed-stage startups and small businesses — managing inventory and vendor relationships and running community events at a small retail shop, hiring and onboarding a team at an early-stage startup, keeping a lean marketing team's tech stack running. Unstructured and shifting priorities is a normal week for me, not an exception.

On location: I'd have no problem moving to Salida — I already have close friends there, so it wouldn't be starting from zero. I'd be glad to be in the office on the schedule this role needs.

I care about climate action beyond this application — it's the thread running through most of what I've chosen to work on lately — and I'd welcome the chance to talk about how I could help LabStart's small team run better.

Thank you for considering my application.

Warmly,

Katrina Engelsted

BOULDER, COLORADO